

are looking for. In the case of lateral hiring, amongst the many other things, candidates need to know how to work with Linux. Having said that, we do not look for experts in open source technologies. We prefer someone who has used Linux with the networking background.

Q Do you train your people when they come on-board, in case you hire someone who does not have a networking + Linux background?

It depends on the level of the position we are hiring for. If we hire people who have one-two years of experience in either networking or Linux, we can train them. But if we are hiring someone who will be the architect for the next module, we are obviously looking for people with more depth in the networking domain than open source technologies. The training feature at any level is project dependant. It is totally a manager's discretion to facilitate training for a capable employee.

Q Are certifications in open source technologies important for the growth of professionals in the IT world today? Do you prefer candidates with such certifications?

Yes. One cannot underestimate the importance of certifications, but it doesn't apply to the freshers that we hire at Juniper. The fresh hires at Juniper go through a fairly rigorous interviewing process, during which they are given programming exercises, etc. So if we have two candidates who do equally well in our programming exercise and one of them has a certification as an add-on, he will get preference. So it helps, but can never be the primary basis for getting a job.

Q Apart from the technical skills, what other qualities do you look for while hiring open source professionals?

It is no different from what we look for when we hire any other professionals. One of the most important factors we look for is whether there is a cultural fit with our company. Every company has a certain culture and way of working. We make each candidate go through three-four interviewers to understand whether the candidate has the cultural fit. Another thing that is happening now-a-days is that there are very few projects on which a person works individually. One has to work with a lot of people sitting in different locations. So, we have to see how much of a team player the candidates are, and if they are comfortable working across different geographies, time zones, etc. It is a little difficult to quantify these parameters but these are some of the criteria that I am sure every company looks for in candidates for their product development teams.

Q Has the demand for FOSS professionals increased in recent years?

Although it would be difficult to quantify the growth in demand, the short answer to this question is, yes. I can see some signs that it has increased. One of the main reasons for the increased demand is the increased supply. You can find

"One of the main reasons for the increased demand is the increased supply. You can find more FOSS professionals in the market today compared to what it used to be, like, five years back."

more FOSS professionals in the market today compared to what it used to be, like, five years back. Also, more and more companies are going in for open source technology. The awareness is there and, hence, I can say that the demand for FOSS professionals is growing in India.

Q How do you go about finding the right FOSS talent for your projects?

There are multiple ways in which we find talent and recruit people. One of the major initiators for hiring is internal reference. About 40 per cent of the people we hire are through this process. We have been in India for over 10 years now and, in the networking industry, our name is quite well known. A lot of people who work in Juniper recommend their fellow professionals. So, we get a lot of internal referrals. We also use social media to a large extent, so tools like Facebook, LinkedIn and other online forums are used to attract the right talent. As mentioned before, we reach out to colleges to hire freshers, and last of all, in some special cases, if we feel that we are not getting the desired talent through these mediums, we seek the help of recruitment agencies as well.

Q Can you throw some light on how many Linux and open source professionals you plan to hire in this financial year?

When we started the company 10 years ago, we were just about 10-12 people and, today, we are about 2,400. We have steadily grown over the years. So, I think these figures give a clear idea about how we have been growing and that is the average growth we want this year as well.

Q How can technology firms that are contemplating open source tools prepare themselves?

I think companies cannot escape from the magic of open source technology. They have to be prepared to keep themselves in the race. Whichever domain of technology you talk about, be it cloud computing, BYOD or even the revolution that mobile devices have brought about, open source technology is everywhere. Open source tools are a way of crystallising these behavioural changes. Users do not want to be restricted to any one tool or alternative. Even when it comes to the development tools, the idea is to use open source tools to facilitate greater scope for creativity. It benefits companies to keep adopting newer technologies. Open source technologies are the order of the day and, hence, the demand for open source professionals is bound to increase. **END** 